

PRODUCT CONCEPT / FRONTEND ONLY

Almost

The Almost Museum - a private museum for unfinished ideas, abandoned projects, failed experiments, and things that almost existed.

A PRIVATE MUSEUM FOR UNFINISHED WORK

01

A portfolio-quality product concept centered on memory, reflection, and deliberate closure.

01 / EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A museum for the work that almost existed

Almost reframes unfinished work as a collection of personal artifacts. Its central experience, The Almost Museum, is intentionally not a task manager, a social network, or a productivity scorecard.

NORTH STAR

Help people preserve the meaning behind unfinished work, then make a calm decision about what happens next.

The product begins with a simple observation: people often abandon projects without abandoning the part of themselves that created them. A screenshot, sketch, draft, or half-built prototype may still contain a valuable idea, even when the original project is no longer relevant.

Almost gives those pieces a place. Each piece becomes an Exhibit with a title, artifact, story, history, and status. The user can revisit it later without being pressured to finish it.

What it is

A local-first archive for unfinished creative and personal work.

What makes it different

The primary interaction is curation and closure, not task completion.

Who it is for

People who collect ideas, experiments, drafts, and projects over time.

The strongest version is private-first. Everything works inside the browser, and the user can export a portable backup or a shareable visual archive when they choose.

02 / PRODUCT FOUNDATION

The problem is not unfinished work. It is lost context.

Most tools remember the task but forget the story: why the work mattered, what changed, and what the person learned by attempting it.

TRADITIONAL TOOLS	THE ALMOST MUSEUM	DESIGN IMPLICATION
Overdue task	Unfinished artifact	Use language that reduces guilt.
Progress percentage	Exhibit status	Focus on meaning and next decisions.
Folder or list	Gallery or room	Make browsing feel spatial and memorable.
Delete or ignore	Archive or release	Make closure deliberate and visible.
Private data hidden in a silo	Portable local archive	Support export and import from day one.

Audience

- Creative people who start more projects than they finish.
- Designers and developers who want to preserve process, not just final work.
- Students and early-career professionals who are building a personal history of attempts.
- Anyone who wants a softer alternative to productivity systems built around pressure.

Product principles

No shame An unfinished item is not presented as a failure or a warning.	Memory over metrics The important question is what the work meant, not how much remains.	Deliberate closure Every item can be revived, archived, completed, transformed, or released.
--	---	---

03 / CORE EXPERIENCE

From unfinished thought to curated exhibit

The product has a clear loop: capture a fragment, add enough context to recognize it later, then revisit it when the user is ready.

01	CAPTURE	Name the thing that almost existed.
02	CURATE	Add the artifact and its story.
03	EXHIBIT	Place it inside a personal museum.
04	REVISIT	Return with context, not pressure.
05	DECIDE	Revive, archive, complete, or release.

The Exhibit object

An Exhibit is the central unit of the product. It is deliberately richer than a task and lighter than a full project-management record.

FIELD	PURPOSE	EXAMPLE
Title	Gives the work an identity.	The Harbor Queue Redesign
Type	Adds a useful point of view.	Project, draft, idea, experiment, message
Museum label	Explains what the work was trying to become.	A calmer way to make waiting feel organized.
Origin story	Preserves why it was started.	I wanted to turn an operational screen into a calm place.
Stopping point	Captures why it paused.	The product direction changed.
Artifacts	Keeps evidence attached to the memory.	Image, PDF, link, audio, or note
Status	Makes the next decision visible.	Unfinished, active, archived, revived, completed, released

04 / PRODUCT STRUCTURE

A quiet gallery instead of a busy dashboard

The interface should feel like walking through a personal exhibition. The visual metaphor is not decoration; it is the way the product organizes memory.

Landing page
A short introduction built around the line: Not everything unfinished is a failure.

Museum lobby
The main collection with grid, timeline, and map views.

Add Exhibit
A three-step capture flow: name it, add evidence, write the label.

Exhibit detail
A framed artifact, story, timeline, and closure actions.

Museum rooms
Visual filters such as Workshop, Archive, and Hall of Second Chances.

Archive settings
Export, import, storage management, and privacy controls.

Suggested navigation

ROUTE	PURPOSE	PRIMARY ACTION
/	Introduce the idea and establish emotional tone.	Enter the Museum
/museum	Browse the user's collection.	Add an Exhibit
/exhibit/new	Capture a new unfinished item.	Save Exhibit
/exhibit/:id	Read and curate one Exhibit.	Revive, archive, complete, or release
/settings	Manage local data and preferences.	Export or import archive

IMPORTANT
SCOPE DECISION

For the first version, museum rooms can be implemented as filters and visual groupings. A fully walkable 3D museum is a later experiment, not an MVP requirement.

05 / SIGNATURE FEATURES

Small mechanics that make the idea feel real

The product becomes distinctive through a handful of interactions that reinforce the museum metaphor without turning it into a game.

Museum labels

Every Exhibit has a short editorial description, like an object in a contemporary museum.

The museum map

Users place related Exhibits near one another on a draggable 2D map.

Almost timeline

The app records starts, edits, pauses, revivals, and closures.

Gentle resurfacing

The app can bring back one forgotten Exhibit without demanding action.

Closure ceremony

Revive, archive, complete, transform, and release each have a distinct result.

Portable collection

Export a JSON backup, an Exhibit page, a poster, or a standalone archive.

Closure actions

ACTION	MEANING	RESULT
Revive	This idea still has energy.	Moves the Exhibit into the active Workshop room.
Archive	This mattered, but it does not need pressure.	Preserves the Exhibit with its history.
Complete	The work reached a meaningful endpoint.	Adds a completion record and date.
Transform	The original project became something else.	Links it to a new or existing Exhibit.
Release	I am intentionally letting this go.	Moves it to a quiet closure state with confirmation.

The tone of these actions matters. A button should say **Move to Archive**, not **Give Up**. The product should make closure feel like authorship.

06 / SCOPE AND ROADMAP

Build the emotional core before the spectacle

The MVP can be genuinely useful without a backend, an account system, or a 3D environment.

MVP

- Create an Exhibit with a title, type, status, story, tags, and optional artifact.
- Persist Exhibits and uploaded files locally in the browser.
- Browse the collection as a responsive gallery with filters.
- Open an Exhibit detail view and edit its story over time.
- Archive, revive, complete, transform, or release an Exhibit.
- Display a basic timeline of creation and status changes.
- Export and import a JSON backup so local data is not trapped in one browser session.
- Support offline use after the first visit.

Post-MVP directions

PHASE	DIRECTION	WHY IT MATTERS
02	Draggable museum map	Reveals relationships and recurring themes.
03	Beautiful poster and HTML exports	Turns private reflection into a shareable artifact.
04	Encrypted local vault	Protects sensitive writing without requiring a server.
05	Optional cloud sync	Adds cross-device access when the local model is proven.
06	Walkable gallery experiment	Adds immersion after the core workflow is useful.

KEEP OUT OF THE MVP

Social feeds, public profiles, collaborative editing, payments, cloud accounts, and automatic AI interpretation. Each one changes the product from a personal archive into a platform.

07 / FRONTEND-ONLY ARCHITECTURE

A local-first product with a clear escape hatch

The technical model is intentionally simple: the browser owns the collection, and export/import gives the user control over backup and portability.

LAYER	RECOMMENDED CHOICE	RESPONSIBILITY
UI	React with a static build	Pages, forms, gallery, detail views, and responsive layouts.
State	Small client-side store	Current Exhibit, filters, modal state, and UI preferences.
Storage	IndexedDB	Exhibit records and uploaded image or document blobs.
Visual map	SVG or Canvas	Drag-and-drop positions and relationship lines.
Offline	Service worker / PWA	Load the app and browse the collection without a network.
Backup	JSON export and import	Portable recovery without authentication or a database.
Security later	Web Crypto API	Optional encrypted local vault when sensitive content is supported.

Suggested Exhibit record

CORE FIELDS

id, title, type, status, museumLabel, whyStarted, whyStopped, whatItTaughtMe, tags, createdAt, updatedAt, closedAt, artifactFiles, relatedExhibitIds, position, and history.

Frontend-only constraints

- Local data does not automatically sync between devices.
- Large video or audio files may need compression or storage warnings.
- Browser storage can be cleared, so export/import must be easy to find.
- Sharing should happen through exported images or standalone HTML, not public records.
- A true multi-device account system is a separate future project.

08 / TECHNOLOGY STACK

Next.js at the front, browser storage underneath

The stack is deliberately client-first: Next.js provides the application shell, while the browser stores Exhibits, artifacts, and history without requiring a server.

LAYER	RECOMMENDED STACK	ROLE IN THE PROJECT
Framework	Next.js App Router + TypeScript	Routes, layouts, metadata, static build, and typed React components.
Styling	Tailwind CSS + shadcn/ui	Custom gallery styling plus accessible UI primitives.
Motion	Motion for React	Gallery transitions, dragging, room changes, and closure moments.
Persistent data	Dexie + IndexedDB	Exhibit records, status history, images, and uploaded file blobs.
Temporary UI state	Zustand	Filters, selected room, open dialogs, and view preferences.
Forms	React Hook Form + Zod	Capture flow, validation, and safe JSON backup imports.
Testing	Vitest + Playwright	Pure data logic plus real browser storage and export workflows.
Deployment	Next.js static export	Generates a deployable static site with no application backend.

Core dependencies

INSTALL	next, react, typescript, tailwindcss, shadcn/ui, lucide-react, motion, dexie, dexie-react-hooks, zustand, react-hook-form, @hookform/resolvers, and zod.
---------	--

Runtime data flow

BROWSER-FIRST ARCHITECTURE	Next.js UI -> Client Components -> Zustand for view state + Dexie for persistence -> IndexedDB for Exhibits and file blobs -> JSON and visual exports. Use /exhibit?id=... for local Exhibit details so unknown browser-created IDs do not need build-time routes.
----------------------------	--

Keep out of the MVP

Do not add Prisma, PostgreSQL, API routes, Server Actions, authentication, cloud file storage, or AI APIs until the local-first workflow is proven useful. Those belong to a later sync or collaboration project.

09 / NEXT.JS SETUP

Start with the official App Router defaults

Use the official create-next-app flow, then keep the framework routing layer separate from the museum's feature and browser-storage code.

Setup checklist

```
pnpm create next-app@latest almost-museum --yes
cd almost-museum
pnpm dev
```

SETUP CHOICE	RECOMMENDATION	WHY
Language	TypeScript	Typed Exhibit records, props, and browser services.
Linter	ESLint	Catches common React and Next.js mistakes early.
Styling	Tailwind CSS	Fast iteration on the editorial museum system.
Source folder	Use src/	Keeps application code separate from root configuration.
Router	App Router	Uses layouts, route segments, loading, error, and not-found files.
Bundler	Turbopack default	Use the current create-next-app default for local development.
Alias	@/*	Keeps imports stable as folders grow.

Static export configuration

```
import type { NextConfig } from 'next'

const nextConfig: NextConfig = { output: 'export' }

export default nextConfig
```

Best-practice folder structure

```
almost-museum/  
src/  
  app/  
    layout.tsx      # root shell and metadata  
    globals.css     # design tokens and global styles  
    page.tsx        # landing page  
    (museum)/  
      museum/page.tsx  # /museum gallery  
      exhibit/page.tsx # /exhibit?id=... detail view  
      settings/page.tsx # /settings local archive controls  
    error.tsx        # route error boundary  
    not-found.tsx    # not-found state  
  components/        # reusable UI and feature components  
    ui/              # shadcn primitives  
    museum/          # gallery, rooms, map, cards  
    exhibit/          # forms, detail, closure actions  
  lib/               # browser services and pure logic  
    db/ export/ validation/ files/  
  stores/            # Zustand UI state  
  types/             # shared TypeScript types  
  public/            # static icons and sample assets  
  next.config.ts     # static export configuration  
package.json / tsconfig.json
```

Official documentation

[Next.js Installation](#) - create the app, run the dev server, and choose the recommended defaults.

[Next.js Project Structure](#) - App Router file conventions, route groups, src/, colocated, and special files.

[Next.js Static Exports](#) - generate the deployable out/ folder for the frontend-only build.

10 / VISUAL AND WRITING DIRECTION

A contemporary archive with room to breathe

The visual system should feel tactile, editorial, and quiet. The museum metaphor should guide hierarchy, spacing, transitions, and copy.

Palette

Warm ivory, charcoal, muted rust, aged brass, sage, and faded blue.

Typography

Editorial serif for titles, neutral sans-serif for interface, mono labels for dates and statuses.

Layout

Large margins, framed artifacts, quiet grids, and clear rhythm between text and evidence.

Motion

Slow fades, gentle card movement, and deliberate transitions during closure.

Texture

Subtle paper grain, thin rules, and imperfect museum-style labels.

Voice

Reflective, direct, and non-judgmental. Never motivational or guilt-driven.

Sample Exhibit copy

THE HARBOR QUEUE REDESIGN

A vehicle queue interface designed to make waiting feel organized instead of chaotic. Started during an attempt to make a dense operations screen feel calm. Paused when the product direction changed. Still worth remembering because it taught me how much atmosphere can change a workflow.

Interface language

INSTEAD OF	USE	REASON
Overdue	Unvisited	Removes the sense of failure.
Delete	Release	Makes the decision intentional.
Task list	Collection	Supports memory rather than urgency.
Progress	History	Shows what happened instead of reducing it to a number.
Give up	Move to Archive	Protects the user's relationship with the work.

11 / PORTFOLIO POSITIONING

A product with a point of view

Almost is valuable as a build because the interaction model, emotional premise, and technical constraints all reinforce one another.

Portfolio case-study angle

What happens to the work we never finish? Almost is a local-first web experience that turns abandoned drafts and ideas into The Almost Museum, a private exhibition for personal work. It helps users preserve context, notice patterns, and choose deliberate closure without converting every creative impulse into a task.

Success criteria

- A new user understands the premise within ten seconds.
- A user can create a meaningful Exhibit in under two minutes.
- The gallery communicates status without looking like a task manager.
- A user can revisit an old project and understand why it mattered.
- Every Exhibit has a clear, non-judgmental closure path.
- The app remains useful with no account, server, or network connection.
- A user can export the collection and feel confident that it is portable.

FINAL PRODUCT STATEMENT

Almost gives unfinished work a place to exist. The Almost Museum is its archive, reflection tool, and gentle decision space for the things that almost became something else.

Recommended next step

Start with one room, one Exhibit type, and one closure flow. Prove that the experience of adding and revisiting an unfinished idea feels meaningful before expanding into maps, exports, or immersive museum spaces.

ALMOST / THE ALMOST MUSEUM / COMPLETE PROJECT CONCEPT

Prepared as a frontend-only product brief